

Production 'Pretentious' 'Tables' No Memorable Moment

By JULIE YESKOVICH

Kaleidoscope Guest Reviewer

Thumbs down . . . Friday night's production of the new El Paso Playhouse's "Separate Tables" was a real dog in the lowest sense of the word.

"Separate Tables" is pretentious, lackluster, boring, mindlessly executed. To top it all off it's overly long. How does a play manage to go so wrong? Let's start at the beginning.

The very selection of this play as the premier for a new season must be questioned. This play of two plays, although why this conglomeration of weak character sketches rates being called two plays escapes logic, revolves around the interaction between two forgettable couples.

The first couple includes a bitter, post-war Marxist, thrown from political power by a drunken attempt upon the life of his frigid, yet alluring, wife.

The wife, recently divorced from her second husband, has just turned forty and discovered sexuality in her drug addicted body. For some befuddled reason comes gunning for the only man she ever really loved. At the end of act one, after a lot of mental, and a touch of physical abuse, the

two ride off into a contrived sunset. Supposedly they live happily ever after.

The couple in the second act is even less believable. They are a latent homosexual masquerading as a retired Army Major and a dimwit. Out of this hodgepodge, the exasperated viewer is supposed to receive some insight into the decline of Britain after World War II.

Playwright Terence Rattigan has made an art out of lethargic action and witless dialogue. "Separate Tables" director Larry Bettis has turned art into science.

His players cower timidly, immobile, as if afraid to move freely for fear of retribution from a director who favors stilted, awkward movements. One wonders if such lack of movement on so small a stage was taught to the actors? Or like a bad habit, it is merely acquired?

The play, set in an aging residential hotel, could have been helped by a set that reflects the intent of the play: once great Victorian splendor, now in serious decline. However, the set, much like the characters, never achieves the pinnacle necessary for decline. It remains unfinished, in need of a few more coats of paint.

But if Bettis and the set designer, who wisely remains as anonymous as his set, must bear the brunt of the criticism, so too must Bettis' cast. They have served him no better than they themselves were served.

The leading roles in each play were portrayed by Leighton Kohloss Dahl and Don Dill. Dahl, although lifeless and lost in her role as the forty-year-old ex-fashion model, is a picture of poise and grace compared to what she does to her role as a 33-year-old retarded girl.

Then there's Dill, whose excuse for a dual role would seem to be a pot belly and a little moustache.

If there threatened to be a memorable moment in the entire production, it came during the second play's parlor scene. Hank Cohen, who seemed to be the only actor in the play not to take himself too seriously, provided a few enjoyable moments during his monologue.

If these words seem harsh, this reviewer invites anyone to set through this three-and-a-half hour debacle. Anyone foolhardy enough to do this should reserve "Separate Tables": one in Laredo, Des Moines, Tokyo — anywhere, but in El Paso.